

Samrat Rana

» BEST OF 2025 BARELY BREAKING A SWEAT

Samrat Rana, all of 20, barely broke a sweat as he became the first Indian pistol shooter to be crowned world champion in an Olympic discipline, in Cairo.

That he first topped qualification and then edged the sensational Hu Kai of China by 0.4 points in the 10m air pistol final only heightened the triumph.

Hu Kai had been virtually unstoppable this season. He had swept gold at all four 10m air pistol World Cups and topped the podium at the Asian Championships. Rana, by contrast, had featured in just one World Cup prior to Cairo, finishing 10th in qualification.

Yet, in the eight-man final, Rana

appeared possessed, cruising to a clutch 243.7. Heading into the final two-shot series, Kai held a slender 0.1-point lead. Usually ice-cool, the Chinese shooter faltered under pressure, firing a 9.5. Rana responded with a 10.2, opening up a 0.6-point advantage with one shot remaining. Kai struck back with a near-perfect 10.8, leaving Rana needing a 10.3 or higher to seal the title. In his previous 23 shots, he had crossed that mark only six times.

But fortune smiled on the young shooter from Karnal, who may have quietly summoned the discipline Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius once praised: "A man's worth is no greater than his ambitions." Rana delivered a 10.6 to clinch the crown. His individual brilliance also powered India to team gold in the men's air pistol event, alongside Varun Tomar and Sharvan Kumar.

Rana further teamed up with Esha Singh in the mixed event, where the Indian pair dominated qualification, dropping just seven points apiece to reach the gold medal match. They had to settle for silver, however, as Hu Kai and Yao Qianxun fired a relentless stream of 10s to hand India a 16-10 defeat.

Rana's appetite for podium finishes carried him to the season-ending World Cup Final in Doha, where he again tested himself against the world's elite. At one stage, he appeared poised for another title run, but a perfect 10.9 for his 20th shot was followed by a costly 8.4 on the 21st. The lapse saw him bow out at the 22-shot mark with a score of 221.5, earning bronze and his first medal at a World Cup Final.

Those performances have lifted Rana to world No. 6 at the time of writing. The boy who began shooting in a makeshift home range has come to embody the scale of India's emerging promise in the sport. His rise is a microcosm of a talent pipeline that is no longer just deep, but increasingly world-ready.

Santadeep Dey

